

ASCENT of the TITAN

From a quiet performer in the background to a figure of authority—in Australia, Anil Kumble comes into his own

■ By Sharda Ugra

The day after he led India to a victory for the ages in Perth, Anil Kumble got up at 7 a.m. like it were any other day. Later, as India nursed hangovers from impromptu celebrations and the rest of his team slept in, he stepped out to get himself some lunch. Dressed in T-shirt, shorts and glasses, he could have been a software engineer on an overseas project exploring his surroundings. Not the man who had, through deed and word, held the world's most formidable cricket team by its throat.

Kumble would cringe at the idea for little he does—other than launch ferocious appeals, arms and legs aquiver like an agitated octopus—registers at a pitch higher than decorous. He is on an overseas project anyway, where a scientific temper has been of more use than tempers of other kinds.

At the end of a bruising contest in Sydney, with emotions at a high, he let his guard down for a few seconds—and the fury of this patient man torched his opposition like a bush-fire. Today, he neither looks back at Sydney nor regrets saying what he did. "What I said had to do with that one match, I don't

